

Construction

For most of human history, construction was largely about piling things on top of each other, whether brick or stone, to create a building. Wood was commonly used for roofing. New materials in the 19th century—first iron, then steel, concrete, and sheet glass—made new kinds of structures possible. Engineers were able to build lighter and more versatile buildings more quickly. Most significantly, they could build much, much higher.



IRON BRIDGE

In 1779, Englishman Abraham Darby built the world's first iron bridge (above), to the design of English architect Thomas Pritchard. Iron was a material previously too expensive to use on a large scale, but new methods of production brought prices down. The bridge's 100-ft (30.5-m) arch spans the Severn River in Shropshire, England. It is still used today.

Steel provides a much stronger framework than stone or brick, which allows for taller buildings.

WOW!

Rising to a massive 2,717 ft (828 m), the world's tallest building is the 160-story Burj Khalifa in Dubai, UAE.



High-rise construction workers bolt together steel girders to form the supporting structure of the skyscraper.